

ARUN JAITLEY

Leader of the Opposition,
Rajya Sabha

- Demanded PM's intervention on the alleged influencing of the judiciary by a Union minister.
- Spoke on the Indo-Pak joint statement.
- Demanded a CVC inquiry into the 2-G spectrum allocation process.
- Spoke on the humiliation of former President APJ Abdul Kalam at IGI Airport



BJP's death knell and went on to say that Congress's victory in the last Lok Sabha elections was a result of circumstances. While she tried to put Home Minister P. Chidambaram on the mat over demand for grants for his ministry, Jaitley blasted the Government and Information Technology Minister A. Raja for the 2-G spectrum allocation process. It's a leadership contest between the two frontrunners.

Born 10 months apart in 1952, they have taken different routes to reach the high point of their political careers. Swaraj has fought many electoral battles. Jaitley is seen by many within the party as a rootless city phenomenon who's more at home in TV studios than in a village election rally. Now that he started getting intimations of leadership glory, he's reaching out to local leaders. The man responsible for the party's wipeout in Delhi has already made trips to Patna and Lucknow. Swaraj, who has never been confrontational within the party, is also working hard to win more friends across the country. Both are aiming for the highest prize: the post of party president that falls vacant in January 2010. Both have the blessings of L.K. Advani, who is busy preparing for one more *yatra*.

Both won't admit that they are in a hurry and a leadership struggle is on. Rajnath Singh, current president, is believed to be supporting Swaraj's

ADVANI FUTURE BELONGS TO THEM ONLY.

in the seating arrangements of senior party members in the Lok Sabha, thereby massaging many hurt egos. Jaitley couldn't afford to be indifferent. He directed his deputy S.S. Ahluwalia to follow suit. Swaraj started the system of having daily meetings with the 12 party whips to ensure full presence of the MPs in the House and to chart out the proceedings of the day. Jaitley too did the same.

However, while Swaraj has adopted a shrill tone for her speeches

and debates, Jaitley prefers to be reasonable and sober. He wants to project the party as a responsible opposition. Though some of his colleagues in the party were critical of his "mild and congratulatory to Congress speech" that he made in response to the motion of thanks on President's address, it earned him praise from the prime minister. The party appreciated Swaraj's speech on the same issue in the Lok Sabha. She took on Congress leader Girija Vyas who sounded the